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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S)

APPROVED MARRIAGES • POLYGYNOUS MARRIAGE

To contract a marriage with someone with whom one must not joke brings in a touch of the anomalous, and that deprives the !Kung of the perfect symmetry and consistency which so content them and make them feel secure in rightness. This society tolerates the anomaly, for obviously it must not forbid marriage in too many categories, and adjusts the joking status by giving to husband and wife the joking relationship as soon as marriage takes place.

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Though neither the sororate nor the levirate is compulsory, marriage is highly approved with the wife of a deceased brother or the husband of a deceased sister. A man is expected to take care of his BrWi should she need his care, even though he is not required to marry her. Marriage with a WiSi or HuBr is also highly approved. Ego has had the joking relationship with these affines.

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A marriage arrangement which the !Kung consider especially good is called *!oa ku*. This means that an exchange is made between two bands: a boy and girl from one marry a girl and boy from the other. *!Oa ku* is not a common practice. Bands as units have no authority in the arrangements of marriages, which is the duty of parents, as I shall describe presently, and parents do not make the exchange between bands a major factor in their choices. If it happens to come about, however, the people are glad because each band thereby gains a person to replace the person lost, and the bonds between the bands are strengthened.

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POLYGYNOUS MARRIAGE

In first marriages, which are arranged by the parents when the boy and girl are still young, the boy is given only one wife. At least this was so in all the instances we knew. Only rarely is a girl given in her first marriage to a man who already has a wife. In instances in which this happens the girl is likely to be the younger sister of the first wife, but not necessarily so. Most polygynous marriages are contracted by the individuals themselves, not by their parents, when the man and the woman have passed their first youth and when widowhood or divorce has made a woman available for remarriage.

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I have the impression that many !Kung men favor polygyny as the ideal form of marriage. Many men among our !Kung informants said they [263](#) aspired to having more than one wife. They pitied Laurence Marshall because the laws of his land forbade his having several, which they considered him able to afford. One said he would not want to live where there were such nonsensical rules. Not all !Kung men, however, wanted more than one wife; some said explicitly that they did not.

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